Diagnosis is also difficult because even a neurotypical person, one who thinks and acts per accepted norms, might show some autistic traits—such as not speaking at the right age or being an introvert. It is not unusual to hear that "everyone is a little autistic". However, while a neurotypical person eventually gets around to normality, an autistic person lives with his or her set of conditions for life. In fact, the confusion over symptoms and their degree hid the scale of the problem for so long that in India autism was included as a disability in law only in 2016, under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act. Undiagnosed and without a chance of treatment, many autistic persons learnt to mask their symptoms to fit into society, bottling up their inner confusion and turmoil.

But known cases are growing. Perhaps as a result of higher instances of accurate diagnosis or the reflection of a greater prevalence of causative factors. Either way, Action for Autism, a Kolkata-based NGO that provides support to people with the condition, estimates that 18 million Indians fall on the spectrum. Concomitantly, the understanding and acceptance of autism is growing too. In fact, it fuelled a whole neurodiversity movement—an acknowledgement that no two brains function alike, and neurodivergent people deserve equal understanding—which is inspiring other adult autistic persons to share their stories. "I don't think my autism is a weakness," says Rakesh. "It is a wiring difference in the brain, which makes me good at a lot of things like pattern recognition, programming, math, logic. But it comes with challenges, especially since the world is built for the majority." Treatment, however, has helped Rakesh slowly gain capabilities he thought he was not capable of. For mothers with young autistic children, the hope for a more neurodiverse world is giving them the courage to find a place for their child in it.



WHAT CAUSES AUTISM?

Two decades ago, if a child did not speak till age three, cowered at the sight of a gathering or kept repeating the same rhyme—all the tell-tale signs of an autistic condition—he or she would have been dismissed as plain shy or, even more

NEW RESEARCH AND THERAPIES

NEW RESEARCH IN AUTISM

- **It can be genetically inherited:** It was assumed that genes that cause autism are not inherited. In 2022, the largest sequencing study of ASD identified four genes in autistic persons that are also present in parents. It confirmed that the genetic cause of ASD could be inherited
- **Screen time is a risk factor:** An analysis of 84,000 mother-child autistic persons in 2022 showed that among boys, longer screen time exposure—television, computers, phones—at age one was related to the emergence of ASD at age three
- **Age of parents has an impact:** A 2016 study showed that women at the start or end of their child-bearing age are more likely to have autistic children. A 2006 study showed that men who father kids after 40 are six times more likely to have an autistic child than men who do so before 30

NEW THERAPIES IN INDIA

- **Applied Behaviour Analysis:** ABA therapy applies our understanding of how behaviour works to real situations. The goal is to increase behaviour that is helpful, curtail those that are harmful or affect learning
- **Genetic research for new therapeutics:** In 2021, researchers at the Jawaharlal Nehru Centre for Advanced Research developed a compound called '6BIO', which, in animal studies, was shown to improve neural function, learning and memory while reducing epileptic seizures
- **Specific therapies:** Unlike broad therapies of the past, today, a variety of specific therapies focus on development of specific skills. This includes play therapy, relationship-forming therapy, music therapy and sensory integration therapy, among others